

The Palmetto Overpass. We crawled out of the Megaplex tunnels like mold from a cracked wall. Stolen turbine, no plates, a tape worth more than the city it mapped.





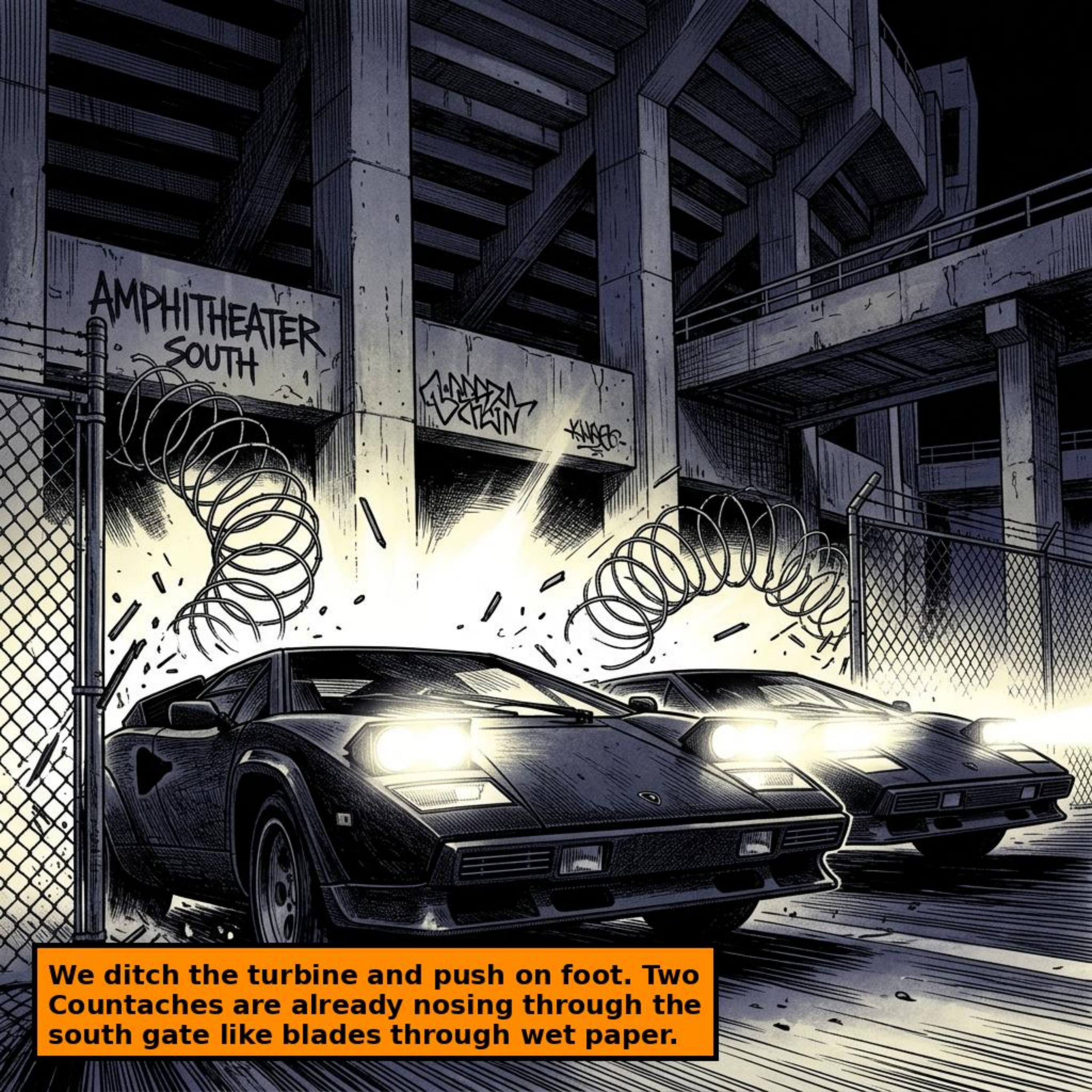
The radio's been dead for six hours. That's not silence. That's the Grid being switched off one node at a time.

Three separate convoys. Three separate vectors. Vanguard from the north, Cartel from the south, Ghost-Roster from the east. All of them want the Tape. Only one of them has my mother's debt on file.



Ghost-roster Vanguard. Vance's off-books unit. They don't file audits. They just collect.



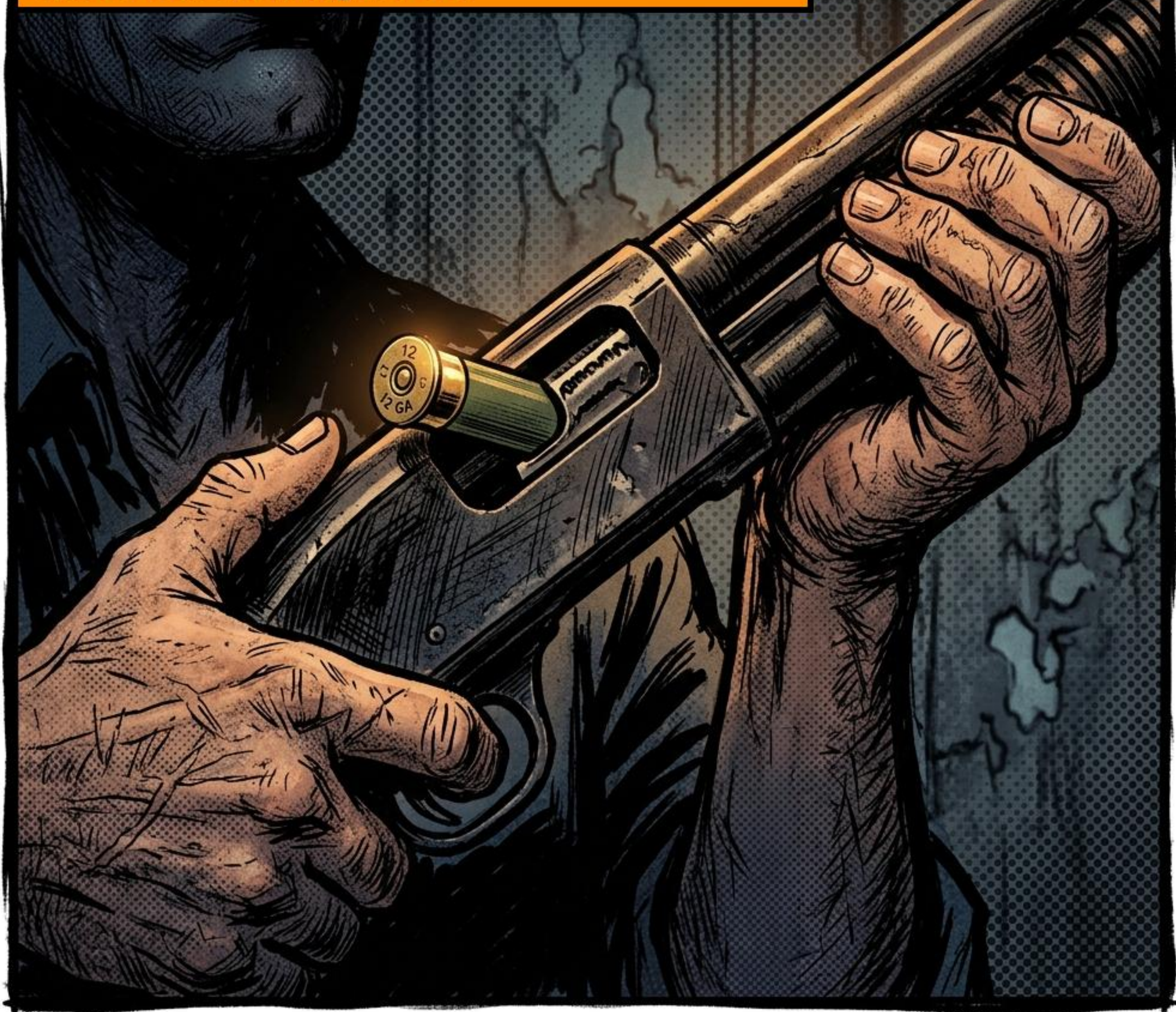


We ditch the turbine and push on foot. Two Countaches are already nosing through the south gate like blades through wet paper.



Through them. Right. Like the whole night hadn't been a controlled demolition of every good option I had left.

One round left in the drum. I'm building from scrap again. We go through the Vanguard perimeter. The Cartel and the Ghost-Roster will do our flanking for us.



NOW, Axel!





CRASH!

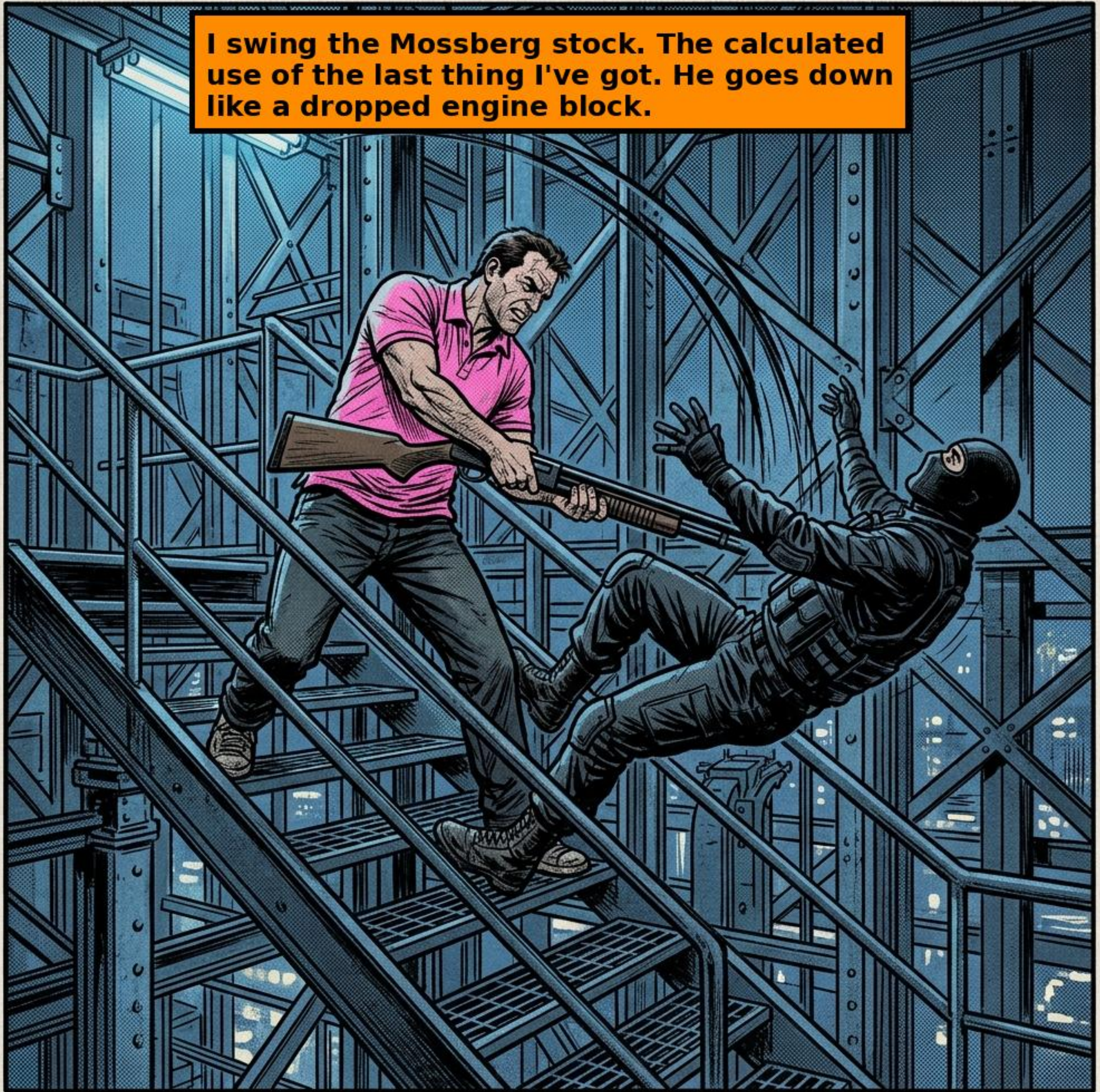
WHEEEZE!

We breach the gap and sprint through the smoke. We stay low, moving through the chaos like two more pieces of debris.

No uniform. No insignia. Just a zip-tie where the Vanguard patch used to be. Quietly. Right.



I swing the Mossberg stock. The calculated use of the last thing I've got. He goes down like a dropped engine block.



I'm into the broadcast array. The Tape's magnetic frequency can jam every comm unit on the field simultaneously. All three factions go blind at once.





The jam hits. Vanguard peels wrong. Two Countaches ram each other at the south gate. The Ghost-Roster freezes, waiting for orders that aren't coming.



The Tape is intact. But Axel—there's a second signal buried in the frequency. Someone else has been reading the Grid. Someone who isn't Vance.